

Lousy Name, Great Game

Agent001

Like most science fiction survival horror games of our times, *Dead Space* starts off with a search and rescue mission – heeding to a distress call from a mining ship called the USG Ishimura. Needless to say things take a sour turn as the rescue ship crashes into the ship in distress. Everything then goes from bad to worse for the three surviving members of the rescue mission, and the priorities shift from rescue to survival. In the thick of this is our protagonist, an engineer named Isaac Clarke (named after science fiction writers Isaac Asimov and Arthur C. Clarke).

As the game progresses, you discover that the USG Ishimura was illegally carrying out a mission in restricted space and nearly its entire crew has fallen victim to an alien infestation. The good news is that the infestation is capable of reanimating the dead into nasty and grotesque creatures. Time to lock and load!

Resident Doom Bio Space (Something Borrowed)

Dead Space takes cues from several successful games in this genre to set up an atmosphere rife with fear, and a claustrophobic feeling of impending doom. As an engineer, your task through most of the game is to fix the failing systems of the USG Ishimura and to make it space-worthy enough to get the hell out of there. Assisting Isaac on his mission is a protective suit of armor (rig) and a decent selection of weapons. An improved version of the suit, that offers better protection and weapons can be purchased at shopping kiosks that are scattered throughout the ship, in exchange for credits. Along with all the weapons, the suit can be upgraded at work benches by using power nodes that can either be bought or found around the ship. Using power nodes to upgrade the suit will improve your hit-points and oxygen capacity. The rig is also equipped with two other abilities: telekinesis, that lets you manipulate object remotely like some sort of gravity gun... and stasis – that slows down objects and creatures. The abilities find use both in combat and outside, the latter to solve environmental puzzles.

These abilities can be upgraded to increase their range and duration. Similarly, upgrading weapons will increase their damage, ammo capacity and reduce the reload time. On accessing a work bench, the game opens up a non-linear upgrade path that can be compared to a circuit board with empty power node slots. There are various options available with the upgrade path and depending on your playing style you can choose the attributes that you want to upgrade while ignoring the rest. Having said that, I feel that choosing between the upgrade options is more of a necessity than choice as there aren't nearly enough nodes available to fully upgrade your arsenal. This also leads the player to select a playing style that further intertwines with your choice of upgrades.

Watch My Back (Something New)

While the game borrows from its genre-leaders, the developers at Redwood Shores Studio have also introduced some very unique elements. First up is the game's style of heads-up display (HUD) and storytelling: the designers have completely done away with the traditional style of displaying information and replaced it with a well thought out way of interfacing with the environment and displaying vital information. The game plays in an over-the-shoulder camera mode, so health is displayed in the form of 'a spine' on the back of Isaac's rig that extends from his neck to his lower back.

Other details like map, inventory and mission objectives, along with video conversations are displayed using holographic projections that do not interrupt the game's flow and allows the player to continue navigating and interacting with the environment. This adds a dose of immersion into the game and also retains the continuity and atmosphere of this science fiction title. Additionally, the game does away with weapon crosshair and instead features an aiming mechanism in the form light beams that extends out the weapons. Also worth mentioning is the level of detail and realism implemented in the main character model. Idle animation shows Isaac's body slightly raising and falling as he breathes and his fingers on the weapons moving over and across it, from time to time. Isaac's head moves and follows objects depending on whether he is watching a holographic projection or assess-

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Publisher: EA

Distributors / Prices
Redington / Rs 2,499 (Xbox 360)
Milestone Interactive Software Limited / Rs 2,799 (PS3)
Excel / Rs 999 (PC)

DEAD SPACE

ing the environment. Taking a certain amount of damage makes his body slump and running animation changes to show him dragging his body along; and low health is further indicated by heavy breathing.

Love You To Pieces

The combat system has been given a fresh coat of paint when compared to what we are used to seeing. Since we are stuck in space, ammo is in short supply and the quickest way to dispatch the cronies is by means of dismemberment. That's right – you need to slowly hack away at the enemies' limbs using your arsenal of ranged weaponry, and then closing in to stomp the freaks to oblivion. If you find yourself out of ammo in the thick of the battle, you can pick up an object using your telekinetic power and hurl them at the enemies. A further layer of depth is added to the combat system by giving an alternate fire mode to every weapon.

The game regularly pits you against new types of enemies, making you constantly think of new and efficient ways of dispatching them. Thankfully, the entire game is not spent inside the ship's corridors and it often throws the player in zero gravity environments and the vacuum of space. As you can imagine, this drastically changes the game dynamics and adds challenges like keeping an eye on your oxygen meter as you dispatch the enemies that come flying at you from all directions. Without giving too much away, let me say that game levels have plenty of variety, and keep the game fresh; rarely will you say 'here we go again'.

Even on normal difficulty, most of the game can be quite challenging, coupled with the dreadful environment and well-scripted (and scary) enemy encounters. There are times when the game can get a little predictable. However, having said that, the game designers have done a pretty good job of keeping the player on the edge most of the time. The developers seem to have a good understanding of the genre and have effectively used lights and sound to make this game quite a scary venture.

The game is divided into 12 chapters and this gives the player roughly 10 hours of gameplay. I imagine, like most games in this genre, the replay value of *Dead Space* is greatly reduced as the game becomes drastically less challenging and scary once you know when and where your next encounter will be. Overall, this is perhaps the best and most innovative title to come out of EA stables in a long, long time and is unfortunately also the most underrated game of this year.

The only way EA can ruin this franchise, is by throwing it in their mill of annual cycles, and not surprisingly, they have already announced a sequel in the making! Sigh.

